

Liberian Jollof Rice

Region: West Africa, Liberia | Tags: West African, One-Pot, Rice, Family Recipe

About This Dish

Jollof rice originated with the Wolof people of Senegal and spread across the continent, with each country and family holding its own version. Our family's Liberian style is hearty, bold, and flavorful, built on a rich tomato-pepper base and long-grain rice, cooked in one large pot. Unlike most versions on the continent, it's cooked with assorted meats. It's a dish made for family and community gatherings, big enough to feed a crowd from a single pot.

Heritage Note

Rice cultivation and one-pot rice cookery travelled from West Africa to the American South through the transatlantic slave trade, forming the foundation of Gullah Geechee cuisine along the Lowcountry coast. Dishes like jollof rice and Gullah red rice share this root: rice as the center of the plate, built up with tomato, pepper, and seasoned protein. *[This section will link to a fuller heritage note once the Region/Heritage_Note data model is populated.]*

Family Story

I learned this dish as a specialty from my mom. She only made it four or five times a year, and one of those times was always my dad's birthday, since it was one of his favorite dishes of hers. Our family version is slightly different in that it's cooked on the stove and then finished in the oven, which really builds a depth of flavor and gets the rich, deep color that's unique to my family specifically. *[Placeholder: add more personal or family context here as needed: who you learned it from, when it's made, what makes your version yours.]*

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice, rinsed
- 3 large tomatoes, blended
- 1 red bell pepper, blended
- 1 scotch bonnet or habanero pepper (to taste), blended
- 1 large onion, divided (half blended, half sliced)
- 1/4 cup regular cooking oil
- 2 tbsp tomato paste
- 2 cups chicken or beef stock
- Assorted protein: chicken, beef, and sausage, seasoned and browned
- Mixed vegetables (carrots, green beans, peas, or similar)
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 bay leaves
- 1 tsp thyme, bouillon or seasoning cubes to taste

- Salt and pepper to taste

Steps

- 1. Blend tomatoes, bell pepper, scotch bonnet or habanero, and half the onion into a smooth base.
- 2. Heat oil in a heavy, oven-safe pot; sauté the sliced onion and garlic until fragrant.
- 3. Stir in tomato paste and cook for 2–3 minutes to deepen the color.
- 4. Add the blended base and bay leaves; simmer uncovered on the stove until it thickens and reduces, building the first layer of color and flavor.
- 5. Stir in stock, thyme, and seasoning; bring to a boil.
- 6. Add rinsed rice and stir to coat, then move the pot, covered, into the oven to finish cooking. This stove-to-oven step is what builds the deep, rich color that makes the family version distinct.
- 7. Check once partway through to fluff and prevent sticking, continuing until the rice is tender.
- 8. Fold in the assorted browned protein, sausage, and mixed vegetables in the final stretch to warm through.
- 9. Rest covered for a few minutes off heat, then fluff and serve family-style from the pot.

Sample wiki-style recipe page, Kitchen Roots by KruehCooks. Structured from the Recipe / Recipe_Ingredient / Tag / Region data model.